

Call with Joanne — 13 Aug, 15 minutes

Fifteen minutes goes fast. Rough shape: **2 min update, 9 min asks, 4 min the things you owe her.**

If you get through only the four starred asks, that is a good call.

Before you dial — review these three things

1. Her answer 1.2, in her words. You will refer to it and it should be exact:

...puts it into a network drive space where the archivists are supposed to review and make final appraisal decisions. **This is our bottleneck.**

2. The record series structure. She may test whether you actually understood it. `(2620191)` = record group `(26)` · series `(20)` · sub-series `(191)`. Two digits, two digits, then two or three. The `_MichaelHart` suffix is her memory aid and is not part of the number. **The key point: it is not unique per delivery** — two accessions from the same office share one.

3. Why we are not adopting ePADD. One sentence, ready to go: *ePADD expects a mailbox handed over as a unit, and your answer 1.7 says email arrives as loose `.eml` and `.pst` files scattered through the same drives as everything else.* Fit, not quality. The Java runtime issue is the second reason, not the first.

Open with this (2 minutes)

"Your document changed the direction of the work more than I expected, and I want to tell you how rather than have it look like the plan quietly shifted."

Then three things, briefly:

- **The bottleneck reframing.** We are not building a front door — you already have one, and Tracy runs it. We are building the step after it, which is where the 49 collections are stuck. That is a better position than the one we thought we were in.
 - **Your answers caught a real error.** We had keyed the data model to the record series number. Since it is not unique per delivery, that would have silently collided the first time an office sent a second batch. Half a day to fix now; a full reprocess of 49 collections later.
 - **The scale is much smaller than we assumed** — around 150,000 files rather than millions. It means we can afford to be careful rather than fast, which suits this material.
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The asks, in priority order

★ 1. An introduction to Tracy Popp

The single most valuable thing from this call. She does format identification and produces preservation metadata upstream of us. Part of what we planned to build may already exist.

You have the questions document ready to hand over. Say that it is short — two pages of questions, priority-marked, and that a conversation would suit us better than a form if she prefers.

If time is short, ask for the introduction and let the rest go.

★ 2. Read access to the network share

Frame it as **smaller than what we were going to ask for**:

"We had been about to ask for a machine we could plug drives into. That turns out to be the wrong ask. What we actually need is read-only permission on the share where those 49 collections already sit. No hardware, no copying, nothing written."

She offered in 1.3 to talk to Tracy and IT about a machine — **head that off** before she spends capital on the wrong request.

Also worth asking: is there anywhere appropriate for a working copy during processing? She said in 5.6 she would find out.

★ 3. The retention window — one number

Ask it as *how long do you want to keep the option open*, not *what is your retention window*:

"Once you have finished selection on an accession, how long should the material you did not select sit before the system starts asking you to dispose of it? Six months? A year?"

We have 180 days as a placeholder. She has already told us the failure mode — no period was set when the backlog came in — so she has a view.

★ 4. One accession profile, and four words

Two small things:

- **One filled-in profile** for an accession she picks. Not 49. The format needs to survive contact with a real person before we standardise it.
 - **Confirm the discipline vocabulary:** humanities / sciences / social sciences / administrative. Explain why it matters — per her answer 3.2, drafts of published work are valuable for a humanities scholar and routine for a scientist. **Same file, opposite outcome, decided by that one field.** It is the least description-like field on the form and the most load-bearing.
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If time allows — in this order

5. Which three or four accessions first, and why? She offered a priority list in 8.3. The reasons matter more than the ranking — they tell us what the Archives values.

6. Review capacity, asked concretely:

"If the system handed you 200 flagged documents, each with a one-line summary and a suggested disposition, is that an hour, a day, or a week?"

Her 6.1 answer gave no number because the question was too vague. This version is answerable.

7. Metadata standards, as a proposal rather than a blank:

"We propose Dublin Core for description and PREMIS for preservation events, mapped to whatever the destination accepts. Does that conflict with anything?"

Much easier to react to than 5.1 was to answer.

8. The Deed of Gift question, rephrased. Her 7.1 answer suggests she thought we wanted to store the Deeds. We do not:

"The Deeds stay where they are. I am asking whether the system should carry a pointer plus the restrictions in enforceable form, so it applies them automatically rather than depending on someone remembering."

9. Can we be represented in the digital strategies exercise? Given Medusa is being replaced inside it, and this system is squarely in scope.

10. Who to talk to about Medusa? She said in 5.5 she would check.

Things you owe her

These matter more than they look. She asked us questions and gave us a lot of her time.

She asked "Which software never deletes?" — give her a straight answer

Do not restate the design at her. Say:

"Fair question, and you were right. Ours does not delete on its own and never will — that part stands. But you are describing the actual lifecycle and I had over-applied the principle. So it now gives the accession archivist a batched deletion action, recorded with who approved what and when. And unselected material goes on a clock, because you identified that the missing clock is what created the backlog. That is the part we built because of your answer."

Tell her about the change we made on her behalf

"In 3.3 you listed HR material — FMLA, discipline matters, personnel discussions — as routinely disposable, and noted it is sensitive in the same sentence. We have treated those as two different outcomes: anything reading as a personnel matter goes to a supervising archivist for review, even when a disposal rule also matches it. Discarding personnel records nobody has read is not recoverable. That was our call, not yours, and you should get to disagree with it."

This is the most important thing you say in the call. It shows the answers are being read carefully rather than mined, and it gives her a real chance to correct us.

The NDA template she asked about

Asked Brent today. Also chasing him on the PII mapping store, which is our one hard blocker.

The draft appraisal rules exist

Her guidance in 3.2 and 3.3 was enough to draft working rules from. Offer to send them:

"It turns the ask from 'write us a policy' into 'check whether we read yours correctly' — which is a much smaller thing. And the 50-file labelled sample becomes a check on our reading rather than a blank-page exercise."

Do not raise unless she does

- The proposal — it has gone to Pramod for approval, and her review is separate. Do not tangle the two.
 - Anything about Gauri's server access. Internal AITS matter.
 - Board mechanics, issue numbers, schema versions. She does not need any of it.
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The one-line summary, if she asks what changed

"The bottleneck is not where we thought it was, the scale is much smaller than we assumed, and your document caught a design error before we built on it. All three are good news."